

PIR - Customers on IE site redirecting to UK site (INC90664432/PBI72110)

M&S Digital&Tech Post Incident Review



Incident/Problem Reference: INC90664432/PBI72110

Incident Date: 14/03/2025

PIR Date: 18/03/2025

Author: Hisham Khalid

Technical Owner:  Chikku Karayath

👉 *Analyses the root cause and provide technical recommendations to prevent incident recurrence.*

👉 *Develop and oversee the implementation of an action plan to address the root causes.*

👉 *Work closely with cross-functional teams to gather information and insights.*

PIR Reviewer:  Sparkes, Luke

👉 *Validates the root cause analysis, corrective actions, and preventive measures before signing off, ensuring alignment with business and operational standards.*

1. Incident Summary :

👉 *Provide a concise overview of the incident with brief update on issue, impact, root cause and resolution.*

The incident began at 9:49am when the Republic of Ireland site started redirecting users to the main UK site, affecting all customers attempting to access the homepage. However, those navigating directly to product listing pages (PLPs) or product detail pages (PDPs) were still able to place orders. The mobile app remained unaffected. This led to a poor customer experience and financial impact, with 4500 unique customers affected and 278 orders, averaging €87 each, impacted during this period.

An incident bridge was initiated, and relevant teams began investigating. All recent changes around the time of the issue were reviewed, leading to the identification of change deployed 9:49am as the root cause. To mitigate the impact, a holding page was deployed on the Ireland site at 10:55am while the team worked on reverting the problematic change.

After rolling back the change and clearing the cache, the holding page was removed, and normal site functionality was restored by 11:42.

The final financial impact calculated by the business is €1.1K after considering the bounce back seen rest of the day.

2. Incident Chronology :

👉 *Include a record of the data/time of key events. e.g. "07:36 Incident started, notified by ..." **keep fact based**".*

09:23 -  <https://github.com/DigitalInnovation/onyx/pull/26...> SEO-74: SEO 74 - move redirects to middleware and redirect page 1 #26793

09:49 - Onyx homepage change deployed and available to IE customers, issue start time

10:00 - Business Ops raised alert  Yusuff, Mohammed: IE redirects to UK

posted in M&S. Com Operations Hub - Chris Sharpe on call until 17th march / TechOps On-call WC 10th March - Priya on 14 March 2025 10:00

10:02 - Service Manager engaged  Tye, Jack: <https://www.marksandspencer.com/ie>

posted in M&S. Com Operations Hub - Chris Sharpe on call until 17th march / TechOps On-call WC 10th March - Priya on 14 March 2025 10:01

10:04 - Akamai team investigated and understood no changes made at

10:10 - Incident channel thread started -  Priyabrata Sahu: ROI Website redirecting UK website

posted in Digital and Tech / Incident Channel on 14 March 2025 10:10

10:20 - Severity 1 incident email and Teams notification sent to the business and Tech stakeholders.

10:32 - Hemal confirmed that reversion merge started

10:47 - 25 more mins to deployment available to all users

10:50 - RD Raine, David suggesting having holding page IE website (homepage), it would impact Apps access. That process takes 2 mins

10:53 - Discussion agreed to have IE holding page

10:54 - Code production deployment started

10:55 - IE holding page put up

10:56 - Dervla has checked whether google has crawled Homepage; women's dresses PLP, women's jeans PLP & women's bras PLP- all of these pages were last crawled before the update was made (so received a 200-status code, no error page)

11:02 - Hemal confirmed deployment has been progressing with SIT2 and then it will deploy to production

11:14 - Production code deployed to Azure EUN region

11:17 - Production code deployed to Azure EUW region

11:19 - Manual validation started with bypassing Akamai header and from origin

11:28 - Cache clear job initiated (<https://github.com/DigitalInnovation/browse-relea...>)

11:33 - Cache clear job completed, validations

11:34 - Agreed to take down holding page from IE website

11:42 - IE website is available for users without redirecting to UK website.

3. Incident Resolution

 *The actions taken to restore services and mitigate impact.*

Once the problem was identified the relevant change was reverted, followed by a cache clear to restore service.

4. Root Cause

 *Refers to the fundamental reason (s) why an incident occurred including problem description, analysis techniques, contributing factors, evidence with concise root cause statements*

The issue was caused by the change in the middleware intended to normalize capital letters in URLs. Previously redirects for capital letters were handled separately for each PDP and PLP template in production. The fix was moved to middleware to simplify the solution and improve maintainability.

However, this change inadvertently caused the region parameter to be lost, leading to a default redirection to the UK site.

Insufficient regression testing across all URLs for both UK and IE sites failed to catch this unintended behavior before deployment.

5. Findings

 *Refer to the key insights and conclusions drawn from the incident analysis - what went well/what went wrong highlighting gaps, failures, or inefficiencies.*

5.1. Observability –

 *Evaluating monitoring, logging, and alerting effectiveness in detecting the incident.*

The Business Operations team identified and reported the issue.

Although no alerts were triggered, an action has been created to setup a new synthetic alert for the IE site.

There is a concern that the IE site may sometimes be overlooked due to its significantly lower traffic compared to the UK site, leading to delayed issue detection. To address this, few actions have been created to improve the testing and awareness.

5.2. Technical Challenges -

 *Identifying system, infrastructure, or architectural issues that complicated resolution.*

The main challenge was the time taken to revert the change. The delay wasn't due to identifying the problem or writing new code but rather waiting for the build pipeline. There was a 15-minute delay in merging the PR and another 20 minutes for deployment. We need to review the production deployment process and how we validate code changes to minimize recovery time.

We got lucky that Google did not reindex significant parts of our website during the timeline.

5.3. MIM involvement & impact assessment -

 *Timely engagement of MIM and analysing the impact on business operations based on top 10 business processes*

The issue was picked from post in the Tech Ops channel by a Service Lead and a bridge was immediately started in the incident channel and managed to completion as a Severity 1.

The customer browsing and ordering impact was immediately clear. However, the impact to SEO was not initially clear an action has been taken to

establish metrics for accurately assessing the impact.

5.4. Incident handling/ stakeholder management –

👉 *Reviewing how teams collaborated to drive the incident to resolution and engaged with key stakeholders.*

Agreed incident handling and stakeholder management processes were followed.

5.5. Business Communication –

👉 *Clear, concise & timely communication to stakeholders, focusing on business impact and recovery actions.*

Initial business communication was sent 10 minutes after the incident bridge was opened, made possible by involvement of two Service Leads.

Managing all aspects of an incident - including sending communications, opening a bridge, engaging technical teams and updating the Loop cannot be effectively handled by a single person while meeting all SLAs.

To improve efficiency, incident management processes and team structures need to be standardized across online and the rest of the portfolios.

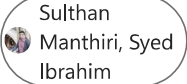
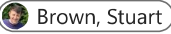
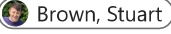
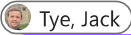
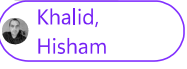
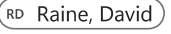
5.6. Supplier & Product team Engagement –

👉 *Assessing the responsiveness and support provided by external vendors and internal product teams.*

There were no 3rd party suppliers involved but the engagement and response of the product teams was as expected in a severity 1 incident.

Mitigation Actions:

👉 *Agree actions for each of the findings to prevent recurrence, strengthen system reliability & stability, and improve response efficiency for future incidents*

	≡ Action	👤 Owner	📅 Due date	≡ Remarks/ Updates	📁 Action Category
1	Alerting		Fri, Mar ...	Synthetic alert for IE homepage.	Problem Identification & Alerting
2	Improve deployment time for Onyx pipeline.	 	Fri, Apr 1...	Selling Experience to articulate the requirements and work with Platform.	Solution & Recovery
3	P1 break glass route to production so changes specific to restoration of service take priority.	 	Fri, Apr 1...		Solution & Recovery
4	IE should be considered in all testing requirements. Review existing tests.	 	Fri, Apr 1...		Problem Avoidance
5	All the product teams to review and familiarize themselves with the severity and risk matrix.	All product teams	Fri, Apr 1...	All the information can be found in this SharePoint page Service Management - Home	Problem Avoidance
6	Review force cache control headers.		Fri, Apr 1...		Solution & Recovery
7	Review standard operating procedure for holding pages.	 	Fri, Apr 1...		Issue handling/ Management
8	Create/improve impact metrics to see if we can identify the precise impact.	 	Wed, Ap...		Problem Identification & Alerting

Please refer to  for progress updates on Mitigations.

Technical Details and Useful Documents: